

August 2026

To Vista School Board of Directors, and the Utah State Board of Education:

My name is Dr. Megan Milne. I am a board-certified pharmacist and the mother of five children, all of whom have attended Vista Charter School in Ivins, Utah. My oldest child was at Vista for ten years and is now a junior in high school. I currently have four children enrolled, ranging from kindergarten through ninth grade. My husband served on the Vista School Board for four years. Our family has been part of this community for twelve years, and my children's closest friends are Vista students and the children of Vista teachers.

I chose Vista because of what it promised. Not just good academics, but something rarer: a school where the arts were not an afterthought but a foundational part of how children learn and grow. For twelve years, that promise was real for my family. My children have participated in the Nutcracker, a production that rivals professional performances. They have been in musicals, orchestra, dance company, show choir. My oldest was in the band program before it was eliminated. All of my children who were old enough loved Mrs. DeLuca's orchestra. My ninth grader is in Vista Rising Stars, Dance Company, and Vista Theatre Company. Vista has given my children elite performing arts training that I could not have provided them anywhere else in Southern Utah.

I am writing this letter because I am watching that school be dismantled, and I have reached the point where I can no longer stay silent.

Written at midnight, May 27, 2026, the night I found out Jake Thomas was not coming back:

I cannot believe that Mr. Thomas has been let go from Vista. He was elected by the ninth graders to speak at their promotion ceremony as the most impactful teacher that they had. Just days ago, he gave an inspiring speech that was better than anything any other teacher or administrator could give. It makes no sense that he would be told his contract would not be renewed because Vista 'is going in a different direction.' It feels like a slap in the face to be asked to donate money for an LED wall for the theater on the same day that they let the teacher go who was the one who requested it, and is the only one who knows how to use it. I was prepared to donate a lot of money for this because I was so excited to see what Mr. Thomas would do. But now I never will, because he'll never be able to do that.

That was my first reaction, written in the middle of the night when I could not sleep. It is still my reaction two months later.

Jake Thomas was not just a theater teacher. He was the stage manager, technical director, and light and sound designer for every single production at Vista: the Nutcracker, the musicals, the dance shows, the orchestra concerts, the assemblies, Vista Rising Stars. He was the person who made it all work. The ninth graders voted for him to speak at their graduation. He gave a

speech that moved the room. Two days later, he was told Vista was "going in a different direction."

What made Mr. Thomas extraordinary was not only what he did, but who he was with his students. He gave every child a nickname. He mentored them in ways that went far beyond stage management and theater instruction. He saw each student and made them feel it. For many Vista children, he was the most important adult outside their family. My daughter was one of them.

My ninth-grade daughter was completely crushed. She has adored Mr. Thomas since she was small. His children are her friends. This is not an abstraction for her. This is the loss of someone who believed in her and shaped who she is becoming. She has struggled to want to return to Vista this year knowing he won't be there.

She processed her grief the way a Vista performing arts student would. She rewrote the lyrics to a song, "Revolting Children," from Matilda, the musical Vista performed last year, to express how she felt. I am including her words here because I believe they say something about what this school means to its students, and what it costs when that trust is broken.

Never again will he get the best of me
Never again will he take away our teachers
And we won't forget the day we
Fought for the right to remove Daddy Blasko
Never again
Will Mrs. Smith get yelled at
Never again
Will JT get kicked out
Never again
Will DeLuca retire for the fear of getting fired
Never again
Will we say 243
Never again

Now that we know we
R-E-V-O-L-T-I-N
We'll S-I-N-G
U-S-I-N-G
We'll be R-E-V-O-L-T-I-N-G
It is 2-L-8-4-U, we are revolting

Written by Lydia Milne, 9th grade Vista student

She is fourteen years old. She rewrote a song from a musical about a child standing up to a cruel headmistress. She did this because she did not know what else to do with what she was feeling. The initials 'JT' in her lyrics are what the Vista Rising Stars show choir kids called Mr. Jake Thomas, a nickname they gave him, the way he gave nicknames to all of them. I am including this because I want the people reading this letter to understand: these are not abstract policy concerns. These are children.

Jake Thomas was the most recent in a pattern that has been unfolding for three years under the current director, Dr. Justin Blasko. The phrase "going in a different direction" was used to dismiss a math teacher, then a PE teacher, then a theater teacher across three consecutive years.

Enrollment at Vista has been declining since Dr. Blasko arrived. Some of these families relocated to Southern Utah specifically to enroll their children at Vista, choosing this community because of what this school promised. They have now withdrawn their children. Yet despite falling enrollment, the administration is pursuing plans to expand Vista into a high school. I am formally asking this board not to approve a high school expansion while the original K-9 school is in this condition. The foundation must be stable before the building can grow.

My children loved Coach Klc. He made PE joyful and interesting. When he was let go with no replacement, my children had no PE for a year. Before that, my oldest child was in the band program when it was eliminated. All of my children who were old enough were heartbroken when Juilliard-trained Linda DeLuca left orchestra. These are not isolated incidents. They are a pattern.

My children's grief over these losses is compounded by another situation I witnessed personally. In May 2026, my son's third-grade teacher, Mrs. Emily Smith, was placed on administrative leave during the week before RISE state testing. My son had been looking forward to testing week because Mrs. Smith had promised her class that it would be a fun week with a celebration afterward. She had spent the whole year building toward it. Instead, my son sat for his state assessments with substitute teachers, unlicensed paraprofessionals, administering his tests. He was confused. The celebration never happened. When Mrs. Smith returned for the last few days of school, there was no explanation. My son did not understand where she had been or why.

I later learned the full story. Mrs. Smith had been selected by her peers as the best teacher at Vista. She was placed on administrative leave not for any legitimate cause, but in what appears to have been a retaliatory action by the administration. There was nothing substantive against her. The administration simply had the power to do it, and they used it.

I recognized this immediately, because I have experienced something like it myself. Years ago, I was treated in a similar way by an employer: targeted, isolated, and subjected to a process designed to intimidate rather than address any genuine concern. I pursued the matter through the U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission. The EEOC ruled in my favor. The employer was found to have violated federal employment law. I prevailed. But it took ten years. Ten years of lost wages, emotional toll, and uncertainty while that injustice went unaddressed.

Justice delayed is justice denied, and in the meantime, others suffered under that same vice president because the process moved so slowly. I think about that when I think about Mrs. Smith. An EEOC path is available to her, but it may well take a decade. And it has already been three years since Vista's math teachers sent formal grievance letters to the state board. Enough time has passed. Enough people have suffered. Enough lives have been irrevocably altered. When I heard what happened to Mrs. Smith, I recognized every part of her story. And this time, I thought: maybe I can actually do something to stop this before it destroys even more people.

Because this is about real people. Mrs. Smith's daughters are my daughters' friends. Mr. Thomas's children are my children's friends. Coach Klc was a real person with a family who was part of this community. Coach Klc's children are my children's friends, because all of these teachers sent their children to Vista. These are not personnel decisions made in the abstract. They are decisions that ripple through the lives of children and families who trusted this school with some of the most important years of their lives.

I have been at Vista for twelve years. I have watched it be something extraordinary. I have also watched it change. I am writing this letter because I am not willing to watch a good thing die without doing anything I can to stop it. Vista's charter names exposure to the arts as a foundational pillar. It promises parental involvement in management decisions. It promises teachers the freedom to pursue instruction methods that yield the best results. Those promises are being broken, quietly and systematically, one departure at a time.

I am asking the Vista Board and the Utah State Board of Education to investigate:

- Whether Vista's charter obligations to the arts are being honored
- Whether RISE testing was administered in compliance with federal requirements for licensed teachers
- Whether the school's leadership environment meets the standard of a safe and professional workplace free from retaliation
- Whether the pattern of departures across three years and three departments reflects a systemic problem requiring board action
- Whether a high school expansion should be approved while enrollment is declining and the existing K-9 program has not been stabilized

I want to be specific about what is in the public record regarding Dr. Blasko's prior position. In December 2021, the Monroe School District Board in Washington state placed him on paid administrative leave after receiving concerns from staff and community members. The board hired an independent third-party investigator to conduct a thorough investigation. That investigation took many months but verified the concerns. The final report was delivered to the board in May 2022. Following that report and subsequent negotiations, Dr. Blasko signed a separation and release agreement and resigned as Monroe School District Superintendent on July 31, 2022. The board voted to formally approve that agreement. This was communicated publicly by the Monroe School District Board to its entire community. It is not gossip. It is documented. The behaviors that prompted that independent investigation are the same behaviors Vista parents and teachers are documenting now, four years later, in a different state. I am not writing alone. A coalition of Vista families has been documenting these concerns for months. We love this school. We are fighting for it because we believe it can still be what it promised to be.

Sincerely,

Dr. Megan Milne, PharmD, BCACP

Vista parent since 2014

Mother of five Vista students